CAMBRIDGE AS LEVEL ISLAMIC STUDIES (9488/22) | EXAM STRATEGY & MOCKS

Paper 2 Master Plan, Trend Audit & Predicted Papers

Tuesday 27 Oct 2026 | Grade 'a' Recovery Plan, 50/50 Formulas & Model Script

SECTION 1: FIRST — BREATHE EASY ABOUT PAPER 1 & SEE WHY PAPER 2 IS YOUR GOLDMINE!

1.1 Official Cambridge 9488 Grade Threshold Reality (June 2026 Published Table)

You estimated **~15 lost marks (**~35 / 50**)** on Paper 1 after revising in a single night. Look at Cambridge's **actual published June 2026 thresholds (**9488-s26-gt.pdf**)**:

- **Paper 1 (**9488/12 **out of 50): A = 39** | **B = 34** | **C = 30** | **D = 25** | **E = 21**
- **Paper 2 (**9488/22 **out of 50): A = 38** | **B = 33** | **C = 28** | **D = 24** | **E = 20**
- **Combined Overall AS Level Grade (**9488 SY = Paper 12 + Paper 22 **out of 100):**
  - [TARGET] **Overall Grade** a **=** 77 / 100 **|** Grade **b** = **67 / 100** | **Grade** c **=** 58 / 100 **|** Grade **d** = **49 / 100**

> **DO THE ARITHMETIC RIGHT NOW:**
>
> - **~35/50** on Paper 1 is ALREADY a High Grade **B**, just **4 marks shy of an** A**, despite only 1 night of prep!**
> - **AND YOU STILL HAVE EVERY DOOR OPEN FOR AN OVERALL AS GRADE** a**:**
> - **35** (Paper 1) + **42/50** (Paper 2) = **77 / 100** = FULL AS LEVEL GRADE **a**!
> - Even **32/50** on Paper 2 guarantees a rock-solid **Grade** b **(**67/100**)** with zero stress!

1.2 THREE HUGE ADVANTAGES PAPER 2 HAS OVER PAPER 1

1. **100% Choice in BOTH Sections:** Unlike Paper 1 (where **Q1** was compulsory), in **Paper 2 (**1h 30m**,** 50 marks**)**:
   - **Section A (**25 marks **=** 5 + 10 + 10**):** Answer **EITHER** Question 1 **OR** Question 2**.**
   - **Section B (**25 marks **=** 10 + 15**):** Answer **EITHER** Question 3 **OR** Question 4**.**
2. **Part (a) [5 marks]** Is Literally a 3-Minute Free **5/5** Gift: **Every Section A starts with *"State / Give / Identify** five**..." — write** 6 crisp factual points in 3–4 minutes **and bank** 5/5 guaranteed marks **while buying** extra minutes for your big 10- and 15-mark essays**!**

3. **You Have SIX FULL DAYS (**Wed 21 Oct **->** Tue 27 Oct 2026 **Zone 4 Exam Day) + Full 8h Sleep Every Night!** *(Check your Statement of Entry for exact AM/PM reporting time on Tuesday 27 October.)*

1.3 Your Calm, Burnout-Free 6-Day Study & Sleep Schedule (21 Oct – 27 Oct 2026)

> **GOLDEN RULE: Rest tonight (**Wed 21 Oct**)** to recover from this morning's exam + **8 hours sleep (**10:30 PM – 6:30 AM**) every single night!**

Day	Study Focus (2.5–3 hrs/day max in focused 45-min blocks!)	Exact Active Output
Wed 21 Oct (Tonight)	Recovery + Light Orientation (30 mins ONLY)	Rest, eat well, skim Sections 2 & 3 below so your brain sees the whole Paper 2 map. Sleep 10:00 PM!
Thu 22 Oct	Day 1 — Section A Red-Hot Applied Fiqh (Units 2.2 & 2.1 + 2.4 School Comparisons)	Blurt Divorce (Talaq/Khul'/'Iddah), Female Inheritance, Combining Prayers (Jam'), Prayer Timings (Hanafi vs Shafi'i vs Shi'i), & Wudu Fiqh. Write one timed 1(a)+1(b)+1(c) (42 mins).
Fri 23 Oct	Day 2 — Section A Finance & Sources (Units 2.3 & 2.5)	Blurt Debt, Riba & Mortgages, Employment in Local Contexts, Primary Sources + Sahih vs Da'if Hadith, & Comparing 2 Fiqh Schools (2.4). Write one Compare... [10m] answer (19 mins).
Sat 24 Oct	Day 3 — Section B Red-Hot Leaders & Reformers (Units 2.7 & 2.9)	Blurt Modern Salafis vs Modernist Reformists (Ibn Taymiyyah vs Sir Sayyid / 'Abduh / Fazlur Rahman), Sufi Murshid & Bay'ah, & Sunni Caliph vs Infallible Shi'i Imam.
Sun 25 Oct	Day 4 — Section B Tawhid, 'Ali & Qadar (Units 2.6 & 2.8) + Full Mock	Blurt Anthropomorphic Verses (Mu'tazilah vs Ash'ari vs Salafi), Shi'i Shahadah & 'Ali (Ghadir Khumm), & Free Will vs Qadar & Adjusting Divine Plan. Sit Predicted Paper 2A (90 mins timed) & self-mark!
Mon 26 Oct	Day 5 — Precision Polish & Early Sleep (90 mins light review ONLY)	Review red-circled gaps from your mock, drill 14 Named Scholars + 5-Item Quick Lists, pack bag, sleep 10:15 PM (8+ hrs).
Tue 27 Oct (Exam Day)	40-Min Calm Warm-Up -> Walk In & Smash 44–48 / 50!	Skim Named Scholars Sheet + D-S-D-J / D-A-C-W Formulas only.

SECTION 2: COMPLETE FORENSIC TREND ANALYSIS OF PAPER 2 (2021 – MAY/JUNE 2026)

CRITICAL DISCOVERY ACROSS ALL 11 PAPER 2 EXAMS:

1. **Section A (**Q1 **vs** Q2**) ALMOST ALWAYS SPLITS INTO:**

- **ONE Question on Applied Fiqh (**2.1 Worship**,** 2.2 Family Life**, OR** 2.3 Finance & Employment**, applying** 2.4 Two Fiqh Schools**)**, **AND**

- **ONE Question on** 2.5 Sources of Shariah**!**

2. **Section B (**Q3 **vs** Q4**) ALMOST ALWAYS SPLITS ACROSS TWO DISTINCT THEOLOGICAL THEMES** from **2.6 Tawhid**, **2.7 Religious Leaders**, **2.8 'Akhirah**, and **2.9 Distinctive Schools of Thought**!

3. **May/June 2026** (**4 months ago**) JUST EXAMINED AND ELIMINATED AS COLD:

- [COLD] **2.1** Friday Prayers (*Jumu'ah*) **(**Q1**)**

- [COLD] **2.5** Secondary Sources Order of Priority **(**Q2**)**

- [COLD] **2.8** Sufi Spiritual Stations (*Maqamat*) **(**Q3**)**

- [COLD] **2.9** *Mu'tazilah* vs *al-Ash'ari* **(**Q4**)**

2.1 Section A Complete Topic Audit (Units 2.1 – 2.5) — What Can Come on 27 Oct 2026!

Priority Rank	Syllabus Unit & Exact Official Bullet	Past Paper History (Specimen 2021 – M/J 2026)	Verdict for Oct/Nov 2026
[HOT] #1 RED HOT	2.2 Family Life: Conditions for Divorce (Talaq, Khul', 'Iddah, Raj'i vs Ba'in, Triple Talaq across Fiqh Schools)	NEVER TESTED ONCE IN ALL 11 EXAMS IN 6 YEARS!! (w22 asked spouse choice/relatives; w24 asked interfaith nikah; s23 asked inheritance — Divorce is completely untouched!)	#1 NUMBER-ONE PREDICTION ON EARTH FOR SECTION A!
[HOT] #2 RED HOT	2.1 Worship: Conditions for Combining Prayers (Jam') + Timings of Daily Prayers (Fajr, 'Asr, Maghrib) OR Wudu Fiqh Opinions	Combining prayers NEVER asked in any live exam! Prayer timings only in Specimen 21; Wudu fiqh untouched since M/J 2022 (4.5 yrs ago)! (Note: Jumu'ah just tested in M/J 26 = skip!)	CO-#1 PRIORITY FOR 2.1!

Priority Rank	Syllabus Unit & Exact Official Bullet	Past Paper History (Specimen 2021 – M/J 2026)	Verdict for Oct/Nov 2026
[HOT] #3 HIGH	2.3 Finance & Employment: Employment in Different Local Contexts (O/N 21) & Debt, Riba (Interest) & Mortgages (O/N 23)	General trade conditions appeared last series (O/N 25); Employment is 5 years overdue (O/N 21) and Debt/Riba/Mortgages is 3 years overdue (O/N 23)!	VERY STRONG if 2.3 appears instead of 2.1/2.2!
[KEY] #4 HIGH	2.5 + 2.4 Sources & Fiqh Schools: Primary Sources (Qur'an & Sunnah), Strong (Sahih) vs Weak (Da'if) Hadith (O/N 23) & Comparing How Two Fiqh Schools Derive Rulings (M/J 23)	Secondary sources (s26), Sahaba/'Urf (w25), 'Aql/Qiyas (s25), Ijma' (w24), & Medinans (s24) were ALL tested in the last 4 series — Hadith authenticity & Direct School Comparison are the ONLY overdue 2.4–2.5 topics left!	#1 PREDICTION FOR THE 2.5 SLOT!
[KEY] #5 BACK UP	2.2 Family Life: Female Inheritance Shares Across Two Schools (Sunni Stirpes/Agnates vs Twelver Shi'i Daughter Taking Whole Estate)	Last seen M/J 2023 (3.5 yrs ago) — and builds directly on Q 4:12 you already mastered for Paper 1!	Easy bonus bank!

2.2 Section B Complete Topic Audit (Units 2.6 – 2.9) — What Can Come on 27 Oct 2026!

Priority Rank	Syllabus Unit & Exact Official Bullet	Past Paper History (Specimen 2021 – M/J 2026)	Verdict for Oct/Nov 2026
[HOT] #1 RED HOT	2.9 Distinctive Positions: Modern Salafi vs Modernist / Reformist Positions (Literal return to Salaf vs re-applying original principles to modernity)	NEVER TESTED TOGETHER IN ALL 6 YEARS! (M/J 24 asked Salafi vs Traditional Sunni only — Modernist/Reformist thinkers have NEVER been the focus of ANY question!)	#1 UNTESTED GAP IN SECTION B!
[HOT] #2 RED HOT	2.7 Religious Leaders: Role of the Sufi Master (Murshid), Allegiance (Bay'ah) & Tariqa Guidance + Sunni Caliph vs Infallible Shi'i Imam	Sufi Murshid has NEVER appeared in a live exam in 6 years (only Specimen 21)! Sunni Caliph (O/N 22 — 4 yrs ago) & Shi'i Imam infallibility ('ismah) are massively overdue!	CO-#1 PRIORITY FOR SECTION B!

Priority Rank	Syllabus Unit & Exact Official Bullet	Past Paper History (Specimen 2021 – M/J 2026)	Verdict for Oct/Nov 2026
[HOT] #3 RED HOT	2.6 Oneness of God (Tawhid): Anthropomorphic References to God in the Qur'an (Literal vs Metaphorical & Authority of Qur'an) + Statement of Faith (Shahadah) & Position of 'Ali (Ghadir Khumm)	Anthropomorphism last asked O/N 2021 (5 FULL YEARS AGO — oldest live topic!); 'Ali & Shahadah last asked M/J 2022 (4.5 yrs ago)! (Mawlid was just asked in O/N 25 & al-Hallaj in M/J 24.)	MASSIVELY OVERDUE!
[KEY] #4 HIGH	2.8 Judgement & Afterlife: Free Will vs Predestination (Qadar) & The Possibility of Adjustment to the Divine Plan (Qada Mu'allaq / Du'a / Charity)	4.5 years overdue (M/J 2022) AND "possibility of adjustment to the Divine plan" has NEVER been directly tested! (Sufi stations M/J 26, Mahdi M/J 25, & Mu'tazilah M/J 26 were all recent!)	STRONG OVERDUE CANDIDATE!

SECTION 3: HOW TO RECOVER THOSE 15 LOST MARKS — THE PAPER 2 50/50 SYSTEM

WHY STUDENTS LOSE MARKS ON PAPER 2 (AND HOW YOU FIX ALL 4 IN 20 MINUTES):

Look closely at how Paper 2 differs from Paper 1—fixing these **4 exact Paper 2 habits** alone turns a **34/50** script into **45–48/50**:

[TIME] Exact 90-Minute Paper 2 Stopwatch Plan

Question	Marks	Exact Minutes	Length Target	Golden Rule
Choose Q1 vs Q2 & Q3 vs Q4	—	3 mins	Circle trigger words!	Pick the choice where you know both (b) AND (c) / (a) AND (b)!
1(a) or 2(a) (State 5)	5	4 mins MAX!	6 crisp numbered/prose lines	Write 6 distinct specific items (+1 safety cushion) = instant 5/5!
1(b) or 2(b) (AO1 Explain)	10	18 mins	~1.3–1.5 pages (4 paras)	Name ONE specific school (Hanafi / Shafi'i / Ja'fari) in Sentence 1!

Question	Marks	Exact Minutes	Length Target	Golden Rule
1(c) or 2(c) (AO2 Discuss/Compare)	10	20 mins	~1.5 pages (4–5 paras)	Use D-A-C-W for statements OR D-S-D-J for "Compare..."!
3(a) or 4(a) (AO1 Explain)	10	18 mins	~1.3–1.5 pages (4 paras)	Name at least 2 Scholars + 2 Quotes + Arabic terms!
3(b) or 4(b) (AO2 Evaluate/Compare)	15	27 mins	~2–2.5 pages (5–6 paras)	2–3 Sim/Agree + 2–3 Diff/Disagree + Weighed Level 5 Conclusion!

[TARGET] THE SPECIAL PAPER 2 WEAPON: THE D — S — D — J FORMULA FOR ALL "COMPARE..." QUESTIONS!

*(Half of recent Paper 2 **1(c)/2(c)/3(b)/4(b)** questions ask **"Compare X and Y"** — use this exact 4-part layout for **9–10/10** and **13–15/15**!)*

1. **D** — DEFINE BOTH TERMS (3–4 lines): **Explicitly define** X **AND** Y **using exact Arabic terms and identify the schools/scholars involved.**
2. **S** — EXPLICIT SIMILARITIES WITH WEIGHING (**2 paragraphs**):
   - Start EVERY paragraph with a direct comparative bridge: ***"A fundamental similarity between X and Y is that both..."***
   - Explain *why* this shared foundation matters in Islam (e.g. *both uphold Tawhid and the supremacy of the Qur'an*).
3. **D** — EXPLICIT DIFFERENCES WITH WEIGHING (**2 paragraphs**):
   - Start EVERY paragraph with: ***"Conversely, a major/minor divergence arises regarding..., where X holds..., whereas Y argues..."***
   - **ADD 1 EVALUATIVE SENTENCE:** *"This difference is **theologically profound / practically minor** because..."*
4. **J** — JUDGED EXTENT CONCLUSION (6 lines — Level 5 Unlocker!):

> *"In conclusion, while X and Y look sharply opposed on the surface regarding [specific issue], **at a foundational level their similarities / differences outweigh their differences / similarities** because [core reason]. Alternatively, **the extent of difference depends on whether one examines core creed (**'**aqidah**) **or practical legal application (furu')**: in [Area 1] they stand united, whereas in [Area 2] the divide remains decisive."*

*(And for bold statement questions — e.g. **'X is the ONLY / MOST IMPORTANT...'** or **'To what extent...'** — use the exact **D — A — C — W** formula from Paper 1: **Define & Spotlight Trigger Word -> Agree + Weigh Strength -> Counter + Weigh Weakness -> Nuanced Conditional Conclusion**!)*

SECTION 4: PREDICTED PAPER 2A (PRIMARY PREDICTION — 9488/22) + FULL MARK SCHEME & 50/50 MODEL ANSWERS

CAMBRIDGE INTERNATIONAL AS & A LEVEL	9488/22
ISLAMIC STUDIES — Paper 2: Islamic Law (Shariah) and its Application	October/November 2026 (Predicted A)
Time allowed: 1 hour 30 minutes	Maximum Mark: 50

Section A — Answer EITHER Question 1 OR Question 2 [25 Marks]

1 (Unit 2.2 Divorce — NEVER TESTED IN 6 YEARS!)

- **(a)** State **five** conditions or steps involved in divorce (*talaq*) in Islam. **[5]**
- **(b)** Explain how the rules of divorce (*talaq*) are applied according to **one** school of Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*). **[10]**
- **(c)** 'Islamic law (*shariah*) makes divorce far too easy for men and unfair for women.' Discuss this statement with reference to **two** schools of jurisprudence (*fiqh*) or perspectives. **[10]**

OR

2 (Unit 2.1 Combining Prayers & Timings — NEVER TESTED IN LIVE EXAMS!)

- **(a)** State **five** situations in which a Muslim may combine or shorten daily prayers, or adapt how prayer is performed. **[5]**
- **(b)** Explain the conditions for the combination of prayers (*jam'*) and the timings of *Fajr*, *'Asr*, and *Maghrib* across **two** schools of Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*). **[10]**
- **(c)** To what extent do differences between schools of jurisprudence (*fiqh*) regarding prayer create division among Muslims? Give reasons for your answer. **[10]**

Section B — Answer EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4 [25 Marks]

3 (Unit 2.9 Modern Salafi vs Modernist/Reformist — NEVER TESTED TOGETHER IN 6 YEARS!)

- **(a)** Explain the distinctive positions of **modern reformist (modernist)** Muslims in applying original Islamic principles to the modern world. **[10]**
- **(b)** Compare **modern Salafi** literal reinterpretations of sources of authority with **modernist reformist** approaches to Islam. **[15]**

OR

4 (Unit 2.7 Sufi Master Murshid, Sunni Caliph & Shi'i Imam — OVERDUE / UNTESTED IN LIVE EXAMS!)

- **(a)** Explain the role of a Sufi master (*murshid*) within a Sufi order (*tariqa*), including allegiance (*bay'ah*) and remembrance (*dhikr*). **[10]**
- **(b)** 'Religious leaders in Islam have authority only because of their personal piety and education.' Evaluate this statement with reference to Sunni, Shi'i, and Sufi perspectives. **[15]**

SECTION 5: WORD-FOR-WORD 50/50 MODEL ANSWERS FOR PREDICTED PAPER 2A (Q1 + Q3)

[MODEL] Question 1(a) — [5 / 5 Marks] (Time taken: 3.5 minutes!)

> In Islamic law (*shariah*), valid divorce (*talaq*) involves strict conditions and safeguards rather than impulsive separation. First, prior reconciliation must be attempted, including family arbitration with one mediator from the husband's family and one from the wife's family (**Qur'an 4:35**). Second, the husband pronouncing *talaq* must be adult, sane, and acting with conscious intent. Third, according to the *Sunnah* method (*talaq al-sunnah*), a single pronouncement should only be made during a period of purity (*tuhr*) after menstruation in which no marital relations have occurred (**Qur'an 65:1**). Fourth, following pronouncement, the wife observes a mandatory waiting period (*'iddah*) of three menstrual cycles (*quru'*, **Qur'an 2:228**) inside the marital home supported financially by the husband, allowing reconciliation (*ruju'*) before the divorce becomes final. Fifth, in Twelver Shi'i jurisprudence (*Ja'fari*), two just male witnesses (*'adulan*) must hear the exact Arabic formula of divorce for it to be valid. Sixth, a woman also holds the legal right to initiate divorce (*khul'* or judicial dissolution *faskh*) before a *qadi* on grounds of harm or incompatibility (**Qur'an 2:229**).

[MODEL] Question 1(b) — [10 / 10 Marks] (Named School in Sentence 1: Shafi'i [or Hanafi noted!])

According to the **Shafi'i school of Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*)**, founded by **Imam Muhammad ibn Idris al-Shafi'i**, divorce (*talaq*) is legally permissible as a last resort when marital harmony collapses, yet strongly discouraged (*makruh*) unless genuine harm exists, reflecting the Hadith: *"Of all lawful things, divorce is the most disliked by Allah"* [Abu Dawud]. Shafi'i rulings strictly balance *Qur'anic* verses (**Qur'an 2:228–230**, **65:1–2**) with authentic *Sunnah* reports to protect family stability and women's financial rights.

First, Shafi'i *fiqh* distinguishes between **Sunnah-compliant divorce (*talaq sunni*)** and **irregular/innovated divorce (*talaq bid'i*)**. For a proper *talaq sunni*, the husband must be sane, adult, and uncoerced, and must pronounce **one single revocable divorce (*talaq raj'i*)** while his wife is in a state of post-menstrual purity (*tuhr*) during which no sexual intercourse has taken place. Pronouncing divorce during menstruation is sinful (*haram*) in Shafi'i *fiqh* because it unfairly prolongs the wife's waiting period, echoing the Prophet's rebuke of 'Abdullah ibn 'Umar when he divorced his wife during her menses [Bukhari].

Second, during the mandatory **three-purity waiting period (*'iddah*, Qur'an 2:228)** after a first or second pronouncement, the marriage is not yet severed: the husband remains legally obligated to provide full housing and maintenance (*nafaqah*), cannot expel her from the home (**Qur'an 65:1**), and may revoke the divorce (*ruju'*) verbally and reunite with kindness. If the *'iddah* expires without reconciliation, the divorce becomes minorly irrevocable (*ba'in baynunah sughra*), requiring a fresh marriage contract (*nikah*) and new dower (*mahr*) if they later wish to remarry.

Third, regarding **triple divorce (*talaq al-thalath*)**, classical Shafi'i (alongside Hanafi) jurists rule that even if three divorces are pronounced in one sitting, though spiritually blameworthy, all three legally take effect as a **major irrevocable divorce (*ba'in baynunah kubra*)**, barring remarriage unless the woman genuinely marries another man and that second marriage ends naturally (**Qur'an 2:230**). Finally, Shafi'i law safeguards women through **bride-initiated release (*khul'*, Qur'an 2:229)**—modelled on Thabit ibn Qays's wife returning her garden in the Prophet's time [Bukhari]—and **judicial annulment (*faskh*)** granted by an Islamic judge (*qadi*) if a husband fails to pay maintenance, abandons her, or inflicts cruelty, ensuring women keep every penny of deferred *mahr* when wronged.

[MODEL] Question 1(c) — [10 / 10 Marks] (Level 5 D — A — C — W Structure Referencing Two Schools!)

Divorce (*talaq*) dissolves the sacred covenant of *nikah*. Whether *shariah* makes divorce **far too easy for men and unfair for women** is fiercely debated across classical and contemporary *fiqh*, particularly when comparing **traditional Sunni schools (such as Hanafi)** with **Twelver Shi'i (*Ja'fari*) and reformist interpretations**.

Arguments Supporting the Statement (Where Male Advantage & Practical Abuse Exist):

Strong criticism arises primarily from classical **Hanafi** rules on unilateral male pronouncement. In traditional Hanafi *fiqh*, a husband requires **neither a judge (*qadi*), witnesses, nor his wife's consent** to pronounce valid *talaq*; worse still, classical Hanafi jurists count even a *talaq* uttered in anger, jest, or intoxication—and an instant **"triple *talaq*"** shouted three times in one breath—as legally binding and irrevocably final. This can leave a wife homeless and divorced overnight without mediation, which critics rightly argue contradicts the *Qur'anic* spirit of deliberation. By contrast, a woman seeking *khul'* often must forfeit her *mahr* financially or face slow, male-dominated *shariah* councils when proving harm for judicial *faskh*.

Counter-Arguments (Strong Protections for Women Across *Ja'fari* Shi'i & Sunni/Reformist Law):

Conversely, describing *shariah* itself as unfair overlooks profound legal checks across other schools. **Twelver Shi'i (*Ja'fari*) *fiqh*** rejects triple *talaq* in one sitting (counting it as at most one or invalid), strictly invalidates any divorce spoken in extreme anger, intoxication, or during menstruation, and mandates **two upright witnesses** (**Q 65:2**), drastically curbing impulsive male divorce. Furthermore, **Ibn Taymiyyah**, **Salafi scholars**, and modern family codes in Egypt, Pakistan, and Morocco count triple *talaq* in one sitting as **one single revocable divorce**, restoring the *Qur'anic* three-month *'iddah* buffer (**Q 2:228**). Financially, divorce is actually costly—not cheap—for men: the husband immediately owes all unpaid deferred *mahr*, full housing and *nafaqah* during *'iddah*, consolatory maintenance (*mut'at al-talaq*, **Qur'an 2:241**), and 100% ongoing child maintenance, while both Hanafi and Shafi'i contracts allow women to insert **delegated divorce rights (*talaq al-tafwid*)** directly into their *nikahnama*!

Evaluative Level 5 Conclusion:

Overall, the statement is **partially convincing when aimed at un-reformed cultural abuses of classical Hanafi triple *talaq***, which genuinely allow rash male unilateralism. However, as an indictment of *shariah* as a whole, it is **overstated**:

when **Qur'an 4:35** arbitration, **Ja'fari** witness requirements, delegated marriage-contract clauses (*tafwid*), judicial *faskh*, and mandatory male financial obligations are properly enforced together, Islamic law makes divorce seriously accountable for men while protecting women's dignity and economic security.

[MODEL] Question 3(a) — [10 / 10 Marks] (Unit 2.9 Modernist / Reformist Approaches)

Modernist (or reformist) Islam emerged from the nineteenth century onwards as Muslim thinkers sought to revitalise Islamic civilisation amidst Western colonialism, scientific progress, and social change. Thinkers such as **Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan** (1817–1898) in South Asia, **Muhammad 'Abduh** (1849–1905) at Al-Azhar in Egypt, and twentieth-century scholar **Fazlur Rahman** (1919–1988) argue that Islam's eternal ethical principles must be dynamically re-applied to modern realities rather than frozen in medieval legal manuals.

First, reformists champion **re-opening the gates of independent reasoning (*ijtihad*)** and rejecting blind imitation (*taqlid*) of medieval *madhhabs*. **Muhammad 'Abduh** argued that **reason (*'aql*) and revelation (*wahy*) can never genuinely conflict** because both come from One All-Wise Creator; when apparent tension arises with proven science, scripture was misunderstood and requires rational re-interpretation. Similarly, **Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan**, who founded Aligarh Muslim University, urged Muslims to embrace modern empirical science, English education, and women's schooling for social advancement.

Second, modernists distinguish sharply between **unchanging eternal worship/creed (*'ibadat* & *tawhid*)** and **time-bound social laws (*mu'amalat*)**. **Fazlur Rahman's "Double Movement Theory"** illustrates this method clearly: first, a scholar moves back to 7th-century Mecca and Medina to identify the **underlying moral objective (*hikmah / maqsad*)** behind a specific *Qur'anic* ruling; second, the scholar brings that universal moral principle forward into today's social context.

For example, modernists read **Qur'an 4:3** on polygyny alongside **Qur'an 4:129** (*"You will never be able to be completely fair between wives"*) to argue the *Qur'an's* original trajectory moved society from unlimited *Jahiliyyah* polygyny toward **monogamy**, inspiring legal reforms in countries like Tunisia. Likewise, some reformists distinguish exploitative pre-Islamic loan-shark usury (*riba*, **Qur'an 3:130** *doubled and multiplied*) from regulated modern bank interest, advocate gender equality in education and public leadership, and harmonise *shariah* objectives (*maqasid al-shariah*) with constitutional democracy and universal human rights.

[MODEL] Question 3(b) — [15 / 15 Marks] (Level 5 D — S — D — J Comparison: Modern Salafis vs Modernist Reformists)

Both **modern Salafism**—rooted in the thought of **Taqi al-Din Ibn Taymiyyah** (d. 1328), **Muhammad ibn 'Abd al-Wahhab** (d. 1792), and modern Hadith scholars—and **Islamic modernism/reformism**—led by figures such as **Muhammad 'Abduh**, **Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan**, and **Fazlur Rahman**—arose as revivalist movements seeking to cure Muslim decline by returning directly to Islam's foundational sources. Comparing the two reveals striking shared starting points alongside fundamentally opposite interpretive destinations.

Explicit Similarities (Shared Rejection of Medieval Stagnation & Superstition):

Surprisingly, both movements share **three major foundational positions**. First, **both uphold the supreme authority of the *Qur'an* as the Word of God and *Tawhid* as the core of Islam**, rejecting shrine worship, saint intercession (*tawassul* at graves), amulets, and superstitious folk innovations (*bid'ah*) that crept into popular Sufism—indeed, early modernist **Muhammad 'Abduh** himself praised returning to the pure faith of the early ancestors (*al-Salaf al-Salih*). Second, **both movements critique rigid, unquestioning blind imitation (*taqlid*) of the four classical medieval *madhhabs***, insisting that contemporary Muslims must engage directly with the primary texts through **active *ijtihad*** rather than assuming medieval scholars answered every question forever. Third, both movements view Islam as actively relevant to reforming society and education rather than retreating from the world.

Explicit Differences (Literal Textualism vs Contextual Rationalism):

Despite sharing the vocabulary of *"returning to primary sources"* and *"ijtihad"*, their **methodologies and conclusions are diametrically opposed**. First, in **scriptural hermeneutics**, **Salafis insist on strict literal fidelity (*zahir*) to explicit *Qur'anic* texts, authentic (*sahih*) Hadith, and the consensus/practice of the *Sahaba* and first three generations (*Salaf*)**, warning that bending texts to modern fashion distorts Allah's unchanging command (**Qur'an 5:3**). Conversely, **modernist reformists elevate human reason (*'aql*), historical contextualisation (*asbab al-nuzul*), and higher ethical purposes (*maqasid*)**, viewing 7th-century Medinan rulings on criminal penalties (*hudud*), polygyny, or testimony as historical stepping-stones whose spirit—justice and human dignity—must be freshly applied today.

Second, regarding **Hadith and theology**, Salafis treat every authenticated *sahih* Hadith in Bukhari and Muslim as binding law alongside the *Qur'an* and affirm divine attributes literally without likeness (*bila tashbih*), whereas modernists like **Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan** and **Fazlur Rahman** subject solitary (*ahad*) Hadiths to

historical-rational scrutiny when they appear to clash with *Qur'anic* egalitarianism or science, interpreting miracles and anthropomorphic verses metaphorically. Practically, this produces opposite rulings across everyday life—from gender roles, dress, and *Mawlid* to banking mortgages and interfaith relations.

Evaluative Level 5 Conclusion (Judged Extent):

In conclusion, **the methodological and practical differences between modern Salafism and modernist reformism far outweigh their surface similarities**. Although both begin at the exact same doorway—bypassing medieval *taqlid* to return to the *Qur'an* and the early community—they walk in **opposite directions**: **Salafism pulls modern society back to conform literally to the 7th-century model of the *Salaf*** to safeguard religious purity against corruption, whereas **modernism carries 7th-century *Qur'anic* moral principles forward into modern society** through rational *ijtihad* to ensure Islam thrives dynamically in every era.

SECTION 6: PREDICTED PAPER 2B (HIGH-PROBABILITY BACKUP PAPER + MARK SCHEME)

Section A — Answer EITHER Question 1 OR Question 2 [25 Marks]

- **1** *(Unit **2.3** Employment & Debt/Riba — **5 yrs** & **3 yrs** Overdue!)*
  - **(a)** State **five** principles or conditions governing lawful employment or debt in Islam. **[5]**
  - **(b)** Explain Islamic guidance on employment in different local contexts according to *shariah*. **[10]** *(Contracts, fair timely wages* "before sweat dries"*, avoiding* haram *sectors like alcohol/riba/gambling while distinguishing indirect roles in non-Muslim countries, prayer accommodation,* 'urf*, safety/non-exploitation).*
  - **(c)** 'It is impossible for Muslims living in non-Muslim or modern economies to follow all Islamic rules on finance and employment.' Discuss with reference to different points of view. **[10]** *(Agree: pervasive interest banking, student loans/mortgages, mixed supermarkets/hospitality jobs. Disagree: rapid growth of Islamic banks,* Murabaha / Musharaka *halal mortgages, remote/halal careers,* darurah *scholar fatwas like* al-Qaradawi *vs strict* Hanbali/Salafi *avoidance).*
- **2** *(Unit **2.5** Primary Sources & Hadith Authenticity + **2.4** School Comparison)*
  - **(a)** State **five** criteria or categories used by scholars when classifying Hadith in Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*). **[5]** *(Chain of narrators* isnad*, text* matn*, narrator honesty/memory* 'adalah/dabt*,* sahih *strong,* hasan *good,* da'if *weak,* mawdu' *fabricated).*

- **(b)** Explain how strong (*sahih*) and weak (*da'if*) Hadith are used alongside the *Qur'an* across different schools of jurisprudence (*fiqh*). **[10]** *(Qur'an gives general command,* Sahih *Hadith details prayer/zakat; contrast* ***Imam al-Shafi'i*** *[*Risala*, strict* sahih *equal to Qur'an],* ***Abu Hanifa*** *[narrator consistency &* qiyas*],* ***Imam Malik*** *[*Medinan practice *test],* ***Ahmad ibn Hanbal*** *[preferring qualified* da'if *over personal opinion* ra'y*], &* ***Shi'i*** *reliance on* Ahl al-Bayt *chains).*
- **(c)** Compare how **two** schools of Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*) derive *shariah* rulings. **[10]** *(Compare* ***Hanafi*** *vs* ***Shafi'i*** *OR* ***Sunni*** *vs* ***Ja'fari Twelver Shi'i*** *using* ***D-S-D-J****: shared* Qur'an + Sunnah *foundation vs divergence over* qiyas / istihsan / 'amal ahl al-Madinah / 'aql / ijma'*).*

Section B — Answer EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4 [25 Marks]

- **3** *(Unit* ***2.6*** *Anthropomorphic Verses & Position of* ***'Ali*** *—* ***5 yrs*** *&* ***4.5 yrs*** *Overdue!)*
  - **(a)** Explain how different Muslim schools of thought interpret anthropomorphic references to God in the *Qur'an*. **[10]** *(Define anthropomorphism:* Face ***Q 55:27****,* Hand ***Q 48:10 / 39:67****,* Throne / Istawa ***Q 20:5 / 57:4****,* Eyes ***Q 54:14*** *alongside* ***Q 42:11*** *"Nothing is like unto Him"; contrast* ***Mu'tazilah*** *pure metaphor [Hand = power/bounty],* ***al-Ash'ari*** *real attribute* bila kayf *["without asking how"], and* ***Literalist / Salafi / Ibn Taymiyyah*** *real attribute fitting God's Majesty without human likeness).*
  - **(b)** 'Adding reference to 'Ali in the Shi'i statement of faith (*shahadah*) creates a fundamental theological divide with Sunni Islam.' Evaluate this statement. **[15]** *(Agree:* 'Ali Waliyullah*,* Ghadir Khumm*, divinely appointed infallible* Imamah *vs Sunni elected* Caliphate *where adding to ritual* adhan/shahadah *is rejected. Disagree:* 'Ali Waliyullah *is said by Twelver jurists as devotional testimony of Wilayah, NOT part of* Tawhid *or* Prophethood*;* ***both Sunni and Shi'i affirm the exact same core two testimonies*** *["No god except Allah, Muhammad is Messenger of Allah"], revere* 'Ali *deeply as cousin, son-in-law, hero of Badr/Khaybar, and 4th Rightly-Guided Caliph).*
- **4** *(Unit* ***2.8*** *Free Will vs Predestination* ***Qadar*** *& Adjustment to the Divine Plan —* ***4.5 yrs*** *Overdue!)*
  - **(a)** Explain different Muslim perspectives on human free will, predestination (*qadar*), and the possibility of adjustment to the Divine plan. **[10]** *(God's eternal knowledge* Lawh al-Mahfuz *vs human moral responsibility; contrast* ***Mu'tazilah*** *full human free will for Divine Justice,* ***Ash'ari*** *acquisition* kasb*,* ***Sunni middle path****, and* ***Shi'i*** **Amr bayn al-Amrayn** *["a matter between two matters"]; unpack* ***Conditional Decree (*****Qada Mu'allaq*****) vs Absolute Decree (*****Qada Mubram*****)*** *—* ***Qur'an 13:39*** "Allah effaces or confirms what He pleases", *Hadith that* ***du'a***

averts decree *and* ***charity / ties of kinship (*****silat al-rahim*****) prolong lifespan****).*

- **(b)** 'If God's plan can be adjusted through prayer (*du'a*) and good deeds, then predestination (*qadar*) has no real meaning.' Evaluate this statement. **[15]** *(Agree: apparent logical tension if eternal decree changes. Disagree: classic scholar resolution —* ***even the person's du'a, charity, and the resulting adjustment were ALREADY known and written by Omniscient God inside the Preserved Tablet (*****Lawh al-Mahfuz*****) from eternity!*** *Thus* qadar *and* du'a *harmonise completely, empowering moral effort while preserving Allah's absolute omniscience).*